

Cover story **TEAM MANMOHAN**

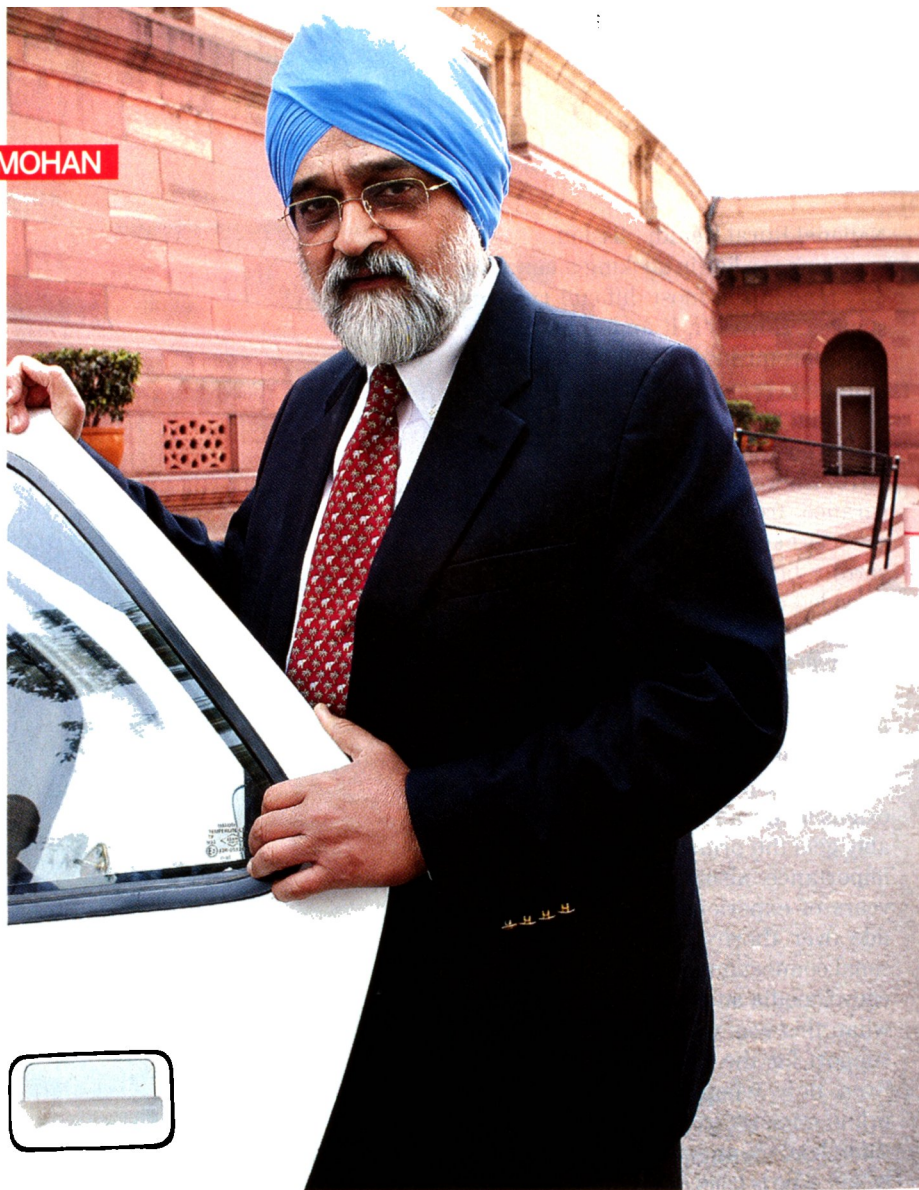
important, I will focus on the holistic nature of national security. There are tremendous strategic opportunities for India," he says.

The last five months of his exile after the Sharm el-Sheikh fiasco have been spent writing a book on diplomacy and mulling over a teaching job at Harvard but now that he is back in favour, he wants to excel in his new job as the national security czar. Menon comes with the earlier experience having served as under secretary in the PMO 40 years ago. In that sense it is familiar territory. As the NSA, his brief is to advise the prime minister on foreign affairs, a task he specialises in and internal security, where he is constantly in danger of crossing paths with Home Minister P. Chidambaram.

Menon also heads the crucial Nuclear Command Authority as well as the National Security Council Secretariat, which deals with long-term threats to national security. The proof of how much the prime minister trusts Menon was apparent when Manmohan called him recently and informed him that he needed to move forward on Pakistan. Menon was ready with a proposal despite reservations from the Foreign Office and members of the Cabinet Committee on Security about the timing of the talks. "He is a smart diplomat and that has helped him. He will tell his boss what the boss wants to hear," says a senior foreign service colleague.

But it is not flattery alone that made Menon win over Manmohan. The prime minister began trusting Menon because he shared the prime minister's worldview and agreed with his vision that India cannot move forward unless it fixes problems in the immediate neighbourhood. The prime minister firmly believes that India is poised to become an economic powerhouse and he believes India should be playing a larger role in the international arena. In that context, he sees Menon, a seasoned diplomat, as someone who can help him cross the t's and dot the i's.

The partnership has already proved a potent one. When the prime minister was getting flak on the Indo-US nuclear deal from the Opposition



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and even members of his own government, it was Menon who stood by him and advised him to stick to his guns. And when NSA M.K. Narayanan was handling the boundary negotiations with China, it was Menon who was advising the prime minister informally. Eventually Narayanan was elbowed out. Menon is also important because he has the rare quality of an intellectual mind and frontline experience of serving in countries like Pakistan, China and Sri Lanka.

Under Menon, major diplomatic initiatives have shifted to the PMO and he is already in the midst of an elaborate exercise to announce some confidence-building measures with China. Despite the tactical mistake of the joint statement with Pakistan at Sharm el-Sheikh, the prime minister has reinforced his trust in him once again, a clear sign of how highly his diplomatic skills are rated.

■ Montek Singh Ahluwalia

DEPUTY CHAIRMAN, PLANNING COMMISSION

FAVOURITE STRATEGIST

His worth lies in liaising with various ministries to ensure that the PMO's targets are met and to ensure the Government is on the same page as the party

There is a reason why they call him the turbanator. Montek Singh Ahluwalia is not just the prime minister's confidant, he is also his chief point man on governance, often liaising with various ministries to ensure that the PMO's targets are met. Interestingly, Manmohan's favourite ideology of inclusive growth, that has now become the UPA's favourite phrase of governance was first coined by Ahluwalia. The approach paper to the Eleventh